"WE CAN TAKE INDIA-NEW ZEALAND TIES TO THE NEXT LEVEL NOW"

On his first visit to New Zealand in October 2022, external affairs minister S. Jaishankar said that the relationship between the two countries is "due for an update and a refresh". New Zealand's foreign minister **NANAIA MAHUTA** *sought to further that in a three-day visit to India from February 7 to 10, and discussed with Jaishankar economic coordination, educational exchanges, defence ties and people-to-people contacts. In an interview with India Today Group Editorial Director* **RAJ CHENGAPPA**, *Mahuta also talks about India-New Zealand ties, the Quad, the Ukraine war and her country's ties with China. Excerpts:*



HER NATION FIRST
Nanaia Mahuta, the foreign minister of New Zealand

Q. Indian foreign minister S. Jaishankar said in October during his visit to New Zealand that the relationship between the two nations was "due for a refresh". What do you think needed to change in the relationship?

NANAIA MAHUTA: I think it was about giving the relationship greater momentum and ensuring consistency in our engagement. New Zealand and India have a positive relationship, but then we didn't have an Indian minister visiting New Zealand for the last 20 years. We hope we can host the president (of India) in the near future. But it's a longstanding relationship; we have people-to-people ties.

Q. What are the two or three key thrust areas you are looking at for the 'refresh'?

Reflecting on the conversations I have had with Jaishankar, there is a common ambition on how we meet our climate change commitments. I think we should extend areas of common interest. New Zealand's expertise in the agriculture sector and in agri-tech might offer enhanced opportunities. Education has been a bridge; we can continue to do more in it. The tech sector is a fast-growing element, there are opportunities there as well.

Q. We just signed a trade agreement

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